

The TikTok Ban Is Economic, Not Security

The official explanation is national security. The evidence points somewhere else. Between 2020 and 2024, the ban tracked market share far more closely than any intelligence finding.

The official story about the TikTok ban runs like this: a Chinese company is vacuuming up American user data, and under China's 2017 National Intelligence Law, that data could end up in Beijing's hands. It's a plausible story. The problem is what happens when you test it.

In 2020, the CIA and the Justice Department looked into the claims. They came back without concrete evidence. The algorithm might carry a risk. The data collection is real. But the same collection happens at Meta and Google, and Washington isn't talking about banning them. If the concern were really about user data, the obvious move would be a federal privacy law covering every platform. The US still doesn't have one.

What the timeline does track, quite closely, is market share. Between 2020 and 2024, TikTok grew from a novelty into one of the largest advertising platforms in the country, cutting straight into Meta's territory. Analysts estimated that a ban would add somewhere near \$431 billion in combined market value to Meta, Google, and Amazon. That's not background noise.

The economic motive shows up elsewhere too. ByteDance hit around \$155 billion in annual revenue by 2024 — roughly Meta's level. Washington's answer wasn't to regulate digital platforms across the board. It was to force one Chinese company to sell to American buyers or shut down, with Microsoft and Oracle waiting to buy. That's not how you handle a security threat. It's how you take out a competitor.

The realist reading is the simple one. States move to protect their economic position, and they reach for justifying language when they do. National security supplies that language cleanly. None of this proves the data worries are invented — they're real, and they're still unresolved. It proves that when those worries line up with commercial interests, the commercial interests tend to set the timing and shape of the response.

China's closed market looks different from the outside, but the logic underneath is the same. Beijing keeps foreign platforms out and calls it sovereignty. Washington pushes Chinese platforms out and calls it security. Both governments are running the same calculation; they just use different words for it.

The next decade of digital advertising will be worth several trillion dollars. The TikTok fight was, when you strip it down, about who ends up positioned to take it.